

Writing for Economics Journals: Elements of Publication Success

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“Even the best scientific research is useless unless it is communicated to others.”²

Abstract

Publication in academic journals is the most prestigious and “desirable” form of reporting research to universities and most research institutions. Getting the research published in appropriate academic journals is one of the most difficult tasks for many graduate students, particularly non-native-English-speaking students. What makes a research paper publishable? This question may have no specific answer for novice authors like graduate students. Thus, this paper tries to help such authors answer the question by looking at several elements of publication success. Unlike much literature on manuscript publishing success in economics journals, the paper examines the elements from the perspective of both editors and referees of economic journals. The elements of publication success that review in this paper are based on two sources. The first source is two surveys conducted by Henderson and Reichenstein in 1996 and by Fisher and Lawrence in 1997. Their surveys ask the questions regarding the perceptions of both editors and reviewers of the major reasons for paper rejections and what they believe to be important to publishing success. The second source is the interviews with one faculty from the Division of Economics and Business at Colorado School of Mines and one economist. According to both surveys, the most consistent reasons for paper rejections by economics journals are the *failure to make a contribution* and the *failure to communicate*. The paper also presents some suggestions, mostly from secondary sources, to help an author improve a manuscript. Although the suggestions are intended specifically for authors of economics journals, most of them also apply to authors of other scientific journals.

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² Ghebremedhin and Tweeten (1988, p.44) cited by Ethridge (1995).

1. Introduction

Almost all graduate students, particularly doctoral candidates, need to conduct research in order to obtain their research degree. One of the most important parts of the research process is *reporting of the research activity*. The written research report is considered as the means of communicating knowledge within the scientific community.

Publication of the research report is important from both the scientific or disciplinary perspectives and for individuals within a discipline. From the disciplinary perspectives, publication represents the primary means of disseminating the products of research within the discourse community. If scientists did not communicate, progress in developing new reliable knowledge would be very slow. For individuals, publication is the primary means of establishing a research reputation and building a career.

Getting the research published in appropriate academic journals is often a daunting task for many graduate students. While English is the international language of business and science, it is not the native language of many of the graduate students of these disciplines. Thus, the research publication seems to be harder for non-native-English-speaking students³.

Some researchers seem to have an ability to get their work published, while others struggle with the publication process. What accounts for this? Some of the factors are specific to the talents of the individual, such as innate ability, training and experience. Yet other factors affecting publication success are somewhat generic and thus attainable by most authors, such as topic selection, journal targeting, timing, and writing quality.

³ For the survey of the role of writing in the graduate program between the non-native-speaking student and native speaking see Jenkins *et al.* (1993).

The purpose of this paper is to focus on the latter factors in hope of discovering practical insights into publication success. Instead of searching such factors from the authors' perspectives, critical elements are examined from the perspective of both editors and referees in economics journals.

2. Reporting research through journal articles

As many of us know, research is reported in many different forms and formats. It is reported in graduate theses and dissertations, paper presentations, working papers and monographs, and so on. These forms of report are important developmental steps toward publication in academic journals.

Publication in academic journals is the most prestigious outlet for the products of research. According to Ethridge (1995, p. 164), the importance of journal publishing is based largely on two considerations:

- (1) Journals have a peer review process for evaluating the quality, relevance, contribution, and importance of written manuscripts and
- (2) journals typically are believed to obtain the widest distribution of all types of research reports among groups of disciplinary and subject matter readers.

Journal articles are terse in their format of reporting research and typically are concerned with space considerations (number of pages). Thus, journal articles are the most condensed forms in which research is reported. The articles are written compactly enough that few persons outside the discourse community can read the paper with confidence, and it is rare for anyone else to even try. The limited audience represents a

disadvantage for disseminating research information through journal articles. Its offsetting advantage is that it is a relatively effective and efficient means of communicating within a group with specialized, focused research interests.

It is not uncommon for publishable manuscripts to be rejected simply because they are ranked below the competition and publication space is limited. Hamermesh (1992) found that the acceptance rate for major economics journals is around 10 percent. Almost all of the leading economists who regularly submit to journals have suffered rejection. A survey conducted by Gans and Shepherd (1994) demonstrated that many classic papers were rejected initially by at least one journal⁴. They also found that most winners of the *Nobel Prize* and *John Bates Clark Medal* have had papers rejected. As they mentioned, rejection usually does not “kill” a paper; a rejected paper usually finds life at another journal. Such findings imply that the author should have a “thick skin,” and it pays to have a “submission tree” in mind, a sequence of alternative outlets for a research.

3. Insights from the Literature

The insights come from other studies, as well as interviews of successful authors from the Division of Economic and Business and industry⁵. Two most interesting articles are founded from the literature reviews. Both of them are the recent surveys of the reviewers and editors of economics journals regarding their perceptions on the major reasons for paper rejections and what they believe to be important to publishing success.

⁴ Gans and Shepherd (1994) also provided the list of some classic papers that was rejected.

⁵ The author would like to thank Professor John E. Tilton and Jaimes Guzman for their interview replies.

The first study is a survey conducted by Henderson and Reichenstein (1996) of 14 frequent reviewers of the *Financial Analysts Journal*, the *Journal of Portfolio Management*, and the *Journal of Applied Corporate Finance*, in order to discover the most frequent reasons for paper rejections by these professional journals. The other study is a survey conducted by Fisher and Lawrence (1997) of the chief editors of 146 economic journals (with 76 editor responses) and the reviewers of 150 academic economists (with 62 reviewer responses).

According to the surveys, the most consistent reason for rejecting a paper is the *failure to make a contribution*. This also really means the author failed to convince a reviewer that the paper makes a contribution. Thus it could be considered a *communication failure*. Other major factors in rejections (some can also be considered as communication failure), in order of importance, are the following:

- Poor organization: parts do not fit into a coherent whole.
- Poorly written: unclear prose, amateur tone.
- Failure to connect statistical results with an economic story.
- Failure to motivate story.
- Topic is inappropriate for journal.

It is also instructive to note the reasons that are not a major factor in rejection but sometimes a paper may be rejected. These factors include the following:

- Writing style is inappropriate for the journal
- Overinterpretation of results.
- Inappropriate quantitative methods.
- Appropriate quantitative methods, but the statistics prove inconclusive.

These factors reflect another communication failure. Most rejections reflect a failure to carefully organize thoughts and express them clearly.

4. Writing Guidelines

The goal of writing in research is to convey information. Good writing is writing that serves its intended purpose. The survey given in the previous section points to two critical criteria for publication success: 1) Have something to say to the journal's readers, and 2) say it clearly.

4.1 Have Something to Say... : Identifying Audiences and Purposes

Before you begin to draft a paper, you first need to figure out what you know and want to say to the journal's readers. Remember that the most common reason for rejecting a paper is the *failure to make a contribution*. Make sure you know what point you want to make before you start to write. Ask whether the paper contributes something new.

Audiences

The first recommended element in conveying information in research writing is to determine the *intended audience* and their information and knowledge needs. Knowing the audience includes an understanding of readers' levels of technical knowledge as well as their interests. Economics journal articles are written to be read by economists. Hardly anyone except professional economists will even attempt to read a disciplinary or subject-matter economics journal.

Purposes

All communication is purpose-driven. As a writer, you should try to anticipate the different purposes that readers may bring to an act of communication. Having your own purpose clearly in mind helps you organize your thinking in a coherent way. And if you make that purpose clear to your audience, they will find it easier to understand your message. If you fail to do this, your audience may try to “create” a purpose for you. What your readers see as your purpose may not be what you see.

4.2 Say It Clearly

Saying it clearly involves telling a story, organizing your thoughts, and writing clearly.

Tell A Story

Tell an economics story and show how the variables are related and why. Remember that the story, not the statistical results, is the contribution to knowledge. Statistics support an economic story; they are not themselves the story.

Henderson and Reichenstein (1996) provided an example of the paper that does not develop an economic story. Regression of “future stock returns” on the “market’s dividend yield” show that both has been statistically associated. For one paper, the only reason given by authors for using dividend yield is “prior studies did it.” They do not explain why “dividend yield” should be related to “future stock returns”. All the reader learns from the paper is that “dividend yield” and “future stock return” has been statistically associated. The reader deserves the “why” and the “so what.”

The ability to tell an economic story is important for authors of economics journals. From a previous example, they should identify the possible economic story. Some scholars claim that the market's dividend yield moves with the unobservable market risk premium, and when the market risk premium is large, average stock returns should be generous and vice versa. That is the economics story. It attempts to explain the statistical evidence.

Organize Your Thoughts

Another reliable guideline is to *organize* what you have to say. You are trying to achieve a *logical order* of presentation of the thoughts and information that is clear, direct, and precise. You want a logical sequencing of thoughts, ideas, and information. You are “directing” your readers’ thinking and understanding. Achieving this logical order requires an *outline* of what you are to present. The outline is a tool for organizing the flow -major points, sub-points, linking points to one another⁶. Henderson and Reichenstein (1996) suggested that several outlines should be prepared in detailed. After each outline, they examined the flow of the arguments and asked if a different organization would make a “story” more convincing. Only after satisfying themselves with the tentative outline did they begin writing the first draft. *A Toulmin Model for Analysis of Arguments*⁷ is another excellent tool that you can use to organize arguments.

Communication of the logical order of thought and information is fostered by several characteristics that can improve your writing. One is *simplicity*. Simple, direct statements communicate more effectively than do complex, rambling, or wordy

⁶ The use of *Text connectives* as well as other *Vande Kopple's metadiscourse elements* help the readers connect, organize, interpret, evaluate, and develop attitudes towards the material.

⁷ See LICM598 class lecture note for this model.

statements. Use simple statements and phrases and avoid unnecessary qualifiers, jargon, and platitudes.

Another desirable characteristic is *precision* (lack of ambiguity) in language. Sometimes a minor difference in the choice of words can alter the readers' perception of the meaning of a statement. For instance, use a phrase such as "demand increased" when the writer really meant "consumption increased" or "quantity bought increased." "Demand increased" describes a shift in a demand curve whereas the other phrases signify either a shift in a demand curve or a movement along a demand curve. The ambiguity or lack of precision on such a fundamental distinction is a grave error for an economist.

Write Clearly

McCloskey (1985) pointed out that clearly written manuscripts are in the minority. He wrote, "At least editors might reveal to the young that rotten writing causes more articles to be rejected for publication than rotten *t-statistics*. Honest. Bad writing does not get read.⁸" As he makes the point, "Writing is thinking." Clear writing requires clear thinking. Writing clearly involves at least good style and review processes.

- *Style*

Style is an essential part of good writing. Each of us has our own style of writing and there is no single appropriate style. In developing your own style, it helps to read good writers; it may help you identify what you are comfortable with and what you like. Most journals have some of their individual style preferences so we should always check

⁸ High (1987) argued that the cost of "bad writing" is low for academic economists. Laband and Taylor (1992) also argued against McCloskey that "poor writing" did not have so much effect on professional success. The paper related "poor writing articles" under McCloskey criteria to subsequent citations and found no evidence to support McCloskey claims.

for any mandated style requirements for any specific journals. There are also general writing guides⁹ that provide guidance on matters ranging from punctuation and grammar rules to creating the mood for writing. *The Science of Scientific Writing* by Gopen and Swan (1990) is an excellent source for improving scientific writing. They related the style with reader expectations.

For non-native-English-speaking students, you may consult *Technical Writing and Professional Communication for Nonnative Speakers of English* (Huckin and Olsen, 1991) for focusing on the features of scientific and technical English that are known to be troublesome for you. These include some general guidelines irrespective of your individual style preferences such as avoiding complex phrases and sentences; making sure you have correct spelling and punctuation; and avoiding digressions into topics not essential to the purpose at hand. There are also some technical points of style that may vary, but you may need to be aware of them.

- *Reviewing*

An essential component of good writing is having what you write reviewed, evaluated, and critiqued by persons who have experience and perspectives in the same type of writing. For graduate students, this should include evaluations and assistance from professors. None of us can be as unattached and analytical with our own writing as with someone else's writing. You want reviewers who are critical, but constructive, so as to help you identify the weaknesses (and strengths) in the drafts you write.

Another useful practice that fosters effective writing is to re-evaluate that writing after it has been set aside for a time. Write a draft, then return to it later, sometimes days or weeks later, with a fresh perspective.

⁹ See Strunk and White (2000), Salant (1969), McCloskey (1983 and 1985) and Thomson (1999).

5. Conclusion

The three most frequent suggestions to authors by editors and reviewers of economic journals are the following:

- Be sure that your paper makes a contribution.
- Suit your paper to the journal (i.e. become familiar with style, length of articles, and audience).
- Write concisely and clearly.

The encouraging news is that writing is a skill that can be learned and the authors can correct most of the problem typically found in submitted papers. All graduate students should take a disciplined approach to learning to write clearly. As the literature suggested, the process of writing reinforces our thinking and vice versa. As we revise our words, we also refine our thoughts and improvements in style lead, in turn, to the sharpening and improvement in the thinking process itself.

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